

YASBANT NEGI



No Fear NSG IS HERE

Used to human shields, many politicians are protesting against Chidambaram's plan to downsize excessive VIP security

| By Bhavna Vij-Aurora |

The President has it and so do the prime minister, most Central ministers, several chief ministers, many members of Parliament and even some ex-MPs. Some, like the President, the prime minister and ministers in sensitive portfolios face genuine security threats from various quarters, but for many others, the ring of beefy armour is a status symbol to be flaunted 24x7. If Home Minister P. Chidambaram has his way, the dividing line between protection and exaggerated threat perceptions will not be as thin as it is now. At least a 100 vips and vvips will have their security cover downgraded by the end of the ongoing budget

session, ending August 7.

A detailed security review has been on since December last after Chidambaram took over as the home minister. Not only has he refused to upgrade his own security cover from Y category to the highest Z-plus, he is pressuring the ministry to "rationalise" the entire gamut of vip security. His predecessor Shivraj Patil enjoyed Z-plus security. Incidentally, Patil figures in the list of vips whose security is to be downgraded.

The statistics tell their own story. The Centre spends over Rs 250 crore annually on providing security to vips, many of whom clearly do not deserve it. There are nearly 400 vips who are provided security in the Capital and one-fourth of Delhi's police force—

15,000 out of a total 60,000—is deployed in protecting them. This is further supplemented by hundreds of paramilitary personnel drawn from forces like the Central Reserve Police Force, Indo-Tibetan Border Police and the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF). The protected include ministers, politicians, bureaucrats, judges, religious leaders and a handful of journalists. Across the country, there are as many as 45,000 policemen guarding 13,000 vips, and the total expenditure is more than Rs 600 crore. Sources in the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) claim that they cannot dictate to the states who they want to provide security to but they can definitely prune and trim at the Central level. The review exercise has re-